THE ARCHITECTURE OF AWAKENING

A Four-Domain Reconstruction of the Buddha's Path to Liberation

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Abstract

This paper reconstructs the Buddha's original meditation system as a four-domain architecture of consciousness, grounded in the early Pāli Canon. It begins by identifying major historical and interpretive distortions—emotionalization of the brahmavihāras, mystification of the jhānas, Western metaphysical overlays, and modern reductions of meditation to attention training—which obscure the functional logic of the path. To correct these distortions, the paper situates the training within its canonical foundation: the Noble Eightfold Path, ānāpānasati as attentional calibration, and satipaṭṭhāna as observational framework.

The reconstruction interprets meditative development as unfolding through four experiential domains—somatic, emotional, relational, and boundary fields—each purified by one of the brahmavihāras and stabilized by the corresponding jhāna. The brahmavihāras are shown not to be ethical emotions but boundless field-states (appamāṇa-vihāras), and the jhānas not trance absorptions but progressive stabilization modes that lock purified domains into coherence. Insight (vipassanā) functions as a system-diagnostic process that reveals the conditioned nature of all four domains, allowing reactive patterns to extinguish.

The integration of purified domains, stabilized by jhāna and clarified by insight, yields the completed architecture described in the Canon as “the Brahmā state” (brahmabhūta), “immeasurable” (appamāṇa), and “unshakeable liberation of mind” (akuppā cetovimutti). Liberation is presented not as mystical illumination but as the structural completion, stabilization, and unbinding of conditioned processes.

By restoring the functional relationships among ethics, breath training, brahmavihāra cultivation, jhāna stabilization, and insight, this paper offers a coherent, systems-level model of the Buddha’s path that resolves conceptual inconsistencies in modern interpretations and clarifies the mechanisms by which consciousness becomes complete.

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1. Introduction

Over the past two and a half millennia, the Buddha’s meditation system has undergone extensive cultural, linguistic, and doctrinal reinterpretation. As Buddhism spread across South Asia, Central Asia, East Asia, and the modern West, its core practices were recast through the lens of local philosophies, religious categories, psychological frameworks, and translation conventions. These reinterpretations often obscured the underlying architecture of the path described in the early Pāli Canon.

In contemporary Buddhism, this fragmentation is particularly apparent. The brahmavihāras are widely presented as emotional virtues rather than the boundless mental abidings (vihāras) described in the Canon. The jhānas are commonly understood as trance-like absorptions or altered states rather than functional stabilization modes of consciousness. “Mindfulness” is frequently reduced to attention training or stress management, severed from its structural role within the Eightfold Path. And the term “enlightenment,” drawn from Western religious and mystical vocabulary, obscures the original canonical conception of liberation as the completion, stabilization, and unbinding of conditioned processes.

These distortions create conceptual noise that prevents modern practitioners and scholars from accurately mapping internal meditative phenomena to the categories used in the early texts. They also obscure the functional relationships among the Eightfold Path, mindfulness of breathing (ānāpānasati), the brahmavihāras, the jhānas, and insight. As a result, the Buddha’s path is often taught as a collection of loosely related practices rather than a unified system of domain purification, domain stabilization, and structural integration.

This paper reconstructs that system by interpreting early Buddhist instructions through a multi-domain model of consciousness. It proposes that meditative development unfolds through the purification of four experiential domains (somatic, emotional, relational, and boundary fields), their stabilization through the four jhānas, and the final diagnostic work of insight. The result is not a mystical illumination but the emergence of an unshakeable, coherent architecture of mind

described in the Canon as “the Brahmā state” (brahmabhūta), “immeasurable” (appamāṇa), and “unshakeable liberation of mind” (akuppā cetovimutti).

By foregrounding the historical distortions that obscured this architecture, the introduction frames the need for a structural reconstruction of the early path. The subsequent sections present this reconstruction systematically, drawing from canonical sources to articulate a functional model of how consciousness is completed.

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2. Contextual Distortions and Their Impact on Understanding the Path

Although the early Pāli Canon presents a coherent and highly structured training system, the transmission of Buddhism across cultures, languages, and historical periods introduced a series of interpretive distortions that obscured the functional architecture of the path. These distortions affect contemporary understandings of the brahmavihāras, the jhānas, the role of ānāpānasati, and the nature of liberation. This section identifies the most consequential distortions, their origins, and their impacts on the mapping of internal states.

2.1 Emotionalization and Moralization of the Brahmavihāras

2.1.1 From Field States (vihāras) to Emotions or Moral Virtues

In the Canon, the brahmavihāras are described as boundless mental abidings—total-field conditions that occupy and shape all domains of consciousness:

> “Immeasurable goodwill… above, below, across, everywhere.” (DN 13.76–78)
>
> “A mind without hostility, without ill will.” (Khp 9.8)

However, in later Theravāda scholasticism and modern popular Buddhism, each brahmavihāra was reinterpreted as a discrete emotional virtue:

- Mettā → kindness / affection
- Karuṇā → empathy / sorrow for suffering
- Muditā → cheerfulness for others’ success
- Upekkhā → detachment / neutrality

This re-framing emerged gradually through:

- Abhidhamma categorization, which treated brahmavihāras as wholesome mental factors (cetasikas), not field-level abidings.

- Commentarial moralization, which integrated brahmavihāras into ethical discourse rather than meditative architecture.

- Victorian-era translations (late 19th century), which favored sentimental Christian moral vocabulary.

2.1.2 Practical Consequences for Meditation

This emotionalization fundamentally distorts practice:

- If mettā is seen as “affection,” practitioners never reach somatic non-hostility, preventing first-jhāna unification.

- If karuṇā is seen as “sad empathy,” practitioners amplify emotional reactivity instead of dissolving it.

- If muditā is seen as “happiness for others,” practitioners fail to purify the relational field (which is about threat, comparison, and envy).

- If upekkhā is seen as “indifference,” practitioners suppress experience instead of stabilizing the boundary field.

Thus, the four abidings cease to function as domain purification protocols, breaking the architecture of the path.

2.2 Mystification and Reification of the Jhānas

2.2.1 From Functional Stabilization States to Trance Absorptions

The earliest jhāna descriptions are phenomenological and functional:

- “Unification of mind” (MN 44)

- “Internal steadiness, internal tranquility” (MN 118)

- “Purity of mindfulness due to equanimity” (MN 10.38)

They describe conditions of field stability, not absorption into altered-state trances.

However, several historical forces altered their meaning:

- Post-Abhidhamma scholasticism elevated the jhānas into specialized attainment categories with narrow definitions.
- Buddhaghosa's Visuddhimagga introduced imagery (e.g., light nimittas) and absorption criteria absent in the early Canon.
- Mahāyāna and Vajrayāna transmissions de-emphasized jhāna relative to conceptual insight or tantric yogas.
- Contemporary Vipassanā lineages (e.g., Burmese) deemphasized jhāna as optional or secondary.

2.2.2 Practical Consequences for Meditation

When jhānas are seen as:

- trance states,
- bliss experiences,
- altered-level consciousness,

practitioners do not use them to:

- stabilize the body field,
- quiet emotional turbulence,
- neutralize relational reactivity,
- establish perfected equanimity.

This breaks the functional pairing between brahmavihāras (purification) and jhānas (stabilization).

2.3 Importation of Western Metaphysical and Mystical Concepts

2.3.1 "Enlightenment" as Mystical Illumination

The term "enlightenment," widely used in modern Buddhism, is:

- not a Buddhist word,

- not a Pāli term,
- imported from Christian mystical theology (“illumination by God”) and
- later embraced by Western romantic and transcendentalist movements.

The Pāli Canon presents liberation using structural-functional terms, including:

- nibbāna (unbinding),
- akuppā cetovimutti (unshakeable mind freedom),
- brahmabhūta (become Brahmā-like: complete, immeasurable),
- anupubbanirodha (gradual cessation).

Equating liberation with metaphysical luminosity or divine union obscures the architectural closure of conditioned domains.

2.4 Loss of Domain Logic in Later Interpretive Systems

2.4.1 Single-Domain Models Displaced the Multi-Domain Architecture

Many later Buddhist traditions emphasize:

- the “mindstream,”
- “emptiness of self,”
- “rigpa,”
- “one-pointedness,”
- “mind-only,”

as if consciousness were a single undifferentiated entity.

This obscured the fact that the Buddha consistently describes experience in terms of multiple aggregates, bases, and fields (e.g., SN 12.2; SN 35.23).

Without domain-logic, the roles of brahmavihāras and jhānas become conceptually isolated.

2.5 Reduction of Meditation to Attention or Stress Management

2.5.1 Modern Mindfulness Movement Distortion

Western secular mindfulness, beginning with Kabat-Zinn, reframed meditation as:

- attention regulation,
- emotional management,
- stress reduction.

This removed:

- the brahmavihāras,
- the jhānas,
- right view,
- right effort,
- insight,
- purification,
- domain dynamics.

It reframed practice as a psychological technique, not a systemic transformation.

2.5.2 Practical Consequences

Practitioners can improve attention while:

- somatic defensiveness persists,
- emotional reactivity remains,
- relational insecurity endures,
- boundary permeability continues.

Thus the four-domain architecture never forms.

2.6 Fragmentation Across Lineages

- **Theravāda** – retains insight and ethics, but often sidelines jhāna and reduces brahmavihāras to virtues.
- **Mahāyāna** – emphasizes compassion, but abstracts it into metaphysics and removes embodied domain-purification logic.
- **Vajrayāna** – emphasizes subtle-energy and advanced yogas, but often lacks foundational training in domain safety and emotional stabilization.
- **Contemporary Hybrid Schools** – cherry-pick techniques from multiple traditions without reconstructing the underlying architecture.

2.7 Overall Impact: Breakdown of the Original System Architecture

Because of these distortions, the functional relationship between:

- the Eightfold Path,
- ānāpānasati,
- the four domains,
- the brahmavihāras,
- the jhānas,
- and insight

has been obscured.

The path is no longer seen as:

> a single integrated system of purification, stabilization, and structural completion.

Instead, it is fragmented into:

- ethics,
- meditation,

- mindfulness,
- emotional cultivation,
- attention training,
- or metaphysics.

None of these isolated components recreates the architecture the Buddha taught.

2.7.1 Summary of Distortion Effects

These distortions produced three critical breakdowns:

1. **Incorrect mapping of internal states** – contemporary practitioners map brahmavihāras and jhānas onto incorrect emotional or mystical categories.
2. **Fragmentation of the training sequence** – key components (brahmavihāras → jhānas → insight) are taught as separate paths.
3. **Loss of the multi-domain model of consciousness** – without recognizing the four domains, purification and stabilization cannot be correctly applied.

These issues justify a full reconstruction of the path based on a structural reading of the Pāli Canon.

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3. The Noble Eightfold Path as Foundational Architecture

The Buddha repeatedly describes a gradual training (anupubbasikkhā) beginning with ethical and behavioral conditioning and culminating in deep meditative absorption and insight (MN 27; MN 107).

The Eightfold Path provides the structural foundation:

3.1 Ethical & Behavioral Ground (Right Speech, Action, Livelihood)

These factors stabilize the external environment, reduce cognitive dissonance, and diminish behavioral causes of agitation.

3.2 Cognitive Orientation (Right View, Right Intention)

Right View aligns the practitioner with causality (paṭiccasamuppāda), rejecting creator-god models and fatalism (MN 2). Right Intention reduces harmful motivational patterns.

3.3 Attentional Training (Right Effort, Right Mindfulness, Right Concentration)

These three factors correspond to samathañca vipassanāca—calming and insight—working in tandem.

The Eightfold Path is thus the scaffolding on which all further training rests.

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4. Ānāpānasati: Fundamental Attentional Calibration

Ānāpānasati (mindfulness of breathing) provides the universal perceptual training for the system.

According to MN 118:

> "Mindfulness of breathing, when developed and cultivated,
> fulfills the Four Foundations of Mindfulness;
> these fulfill the Seven Awakening Factors;
> these fulfill knowledge and liberation."
> (MN 118.10–18)

This practice trains direct contact with the four experiential classes:

- **Body (kāya)** — breathing, posture, tension, energy (MN 118.3–4)
- **Feeling-tones (vedanā)** — pleasant, unpleasant, neutral (MN 118.6–7)
- **Mind (citta)** — moods, states, clarity (MN 118.8–9)
- **Phenomena (dhammā)** — laws, patterns, reactivity (MN 118.10–16)

Ānāpānasati therefore functions as a system-wide calibration method, enabling observation of the domains without distortion.

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5. The Four Domains of Consciousness

The Pāli Canon describes consciousness as distributed across multiple experiential “fields” or modes in which the mind “dwells” (vihāra). The brahmavihāras are explicitly described as abidings (DN 13.76–78).

These four fields form the basis of the domain model:

5.1 Somatic / Body Field

The visceral field of tension, warmth, breath, pressure, and embodied presence.

5.2 Subtle Emotional Field

Tones, moods, and affective atmospheres—expansive or contracted.

5.3 Relational / Contact Field

The interface between self and other—perceived threat, resonance, comparison.

5.4 Boundary / Perimeter Field

The outer “container” of experience—porous or stable, reactive or equanimous.

These domains are conditioned, dynamic, and interdependent.

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6. Brahmavihāras as Domain Purification Protocols

In this model, the four Brahmavihāras are not moral emotions or attitudes but **domain-wide purification modes**. Each one is a specific way the mind learns to inhabit a field of experience without distortion. The traditional English glosses ("loving-kindness," "compassion," etc.) are therefore misleading: they collapse a complex, multi-layered field-state into an emotion that can be imitated conceptually.

Here, we treat the Pāli terms themselves—**mettā, karuṇā, muditā, upekkhā**—as primary, and describe what they actually *do* in the body, the nervous system, and the four domains.

6.1 Mettā — Purifying the Somatic Domain

Mettā is the purification of the **somatic / body field**. Canonically, it is described as an immeasurable radiation of non-hostility and non-ill-will (DN 13.76–78; Khp 9.6–9.8; AN 4.125).

Functional definition
Mettā is a **stable field of somatic non-hostility**. The body ceases to generate defensive

patterns. There is no tightening against experience, no pushing away, no internal "flinch" anywhere in the field.

Phenomenology (what it actually feels like):

- A warm, buoyant, golden radiance centered in the chest but diffused through the whole body.
- Muscles and fascia feel unarmored; breath moves freely.
- An effortless, global sense of friendliness toward all beings, including oneself, that manifests first as full-body ease.

Domain location:

- The **somatic field**: tension, temperature, pressure, breath, visceral tone.

Distortions it purifies:

- Aversion and threat response.
- Protective contraction and bracing.
- Somatic habits of flinching, freezing, or hardening.

Practice pointer (felt-sense cue):

> "My whole body is broadcasting friendliness in every direction—nothing in me is against anything that exists."

6.2 Karuṇā — Purifying the Emotional Domain

Karuṇā is the purification of the **subtle emotional field**. In the Canon it is "abundant, exalted, immeasurable" compassion radiating to all beings (DN 13.76; AN 6.13), not a mood of sorrow or pity.

Functional definition
Karuṇā is **luminous, active responsiveness to suffering**. Wherever dukkha appears—in oneself or others—the heart meets it with an immediate, effortless wish for its cessation.

Phenomenology:

- A bright, soft, oscillating wave from the heart that seems to "scan" for pain.
- When it contacts suffering, there is a spontaneous, joyful impulse: "May this end right now."
- Emotional turbulence is absorbed and dissolved rather than mirrored or amplified.

Domain location:

- The **emotional / affective field**: moods, tones, felt atmospheres in and around the chest and head.

Distortions it purifies:

- Sorrow that collapses into helplessness.
- Resentment, emotional numbing, and defensive withdrawal.
- Reactive aversion to one's own or others' pain.

Practice pointer:

> "A warm, radiant wave flows from my chest and joyfully dissolves every trace of pain it touches."

6.3 Muditā — Purifying the Relational Domain

Muditā is the purification of the **relational / contact field**. Canonically, it is "immeasurable gladness" that banishes envy and hostility (DN 13.77; AN 5.161).

Functional definition
Muditā is **resonant joy in the goodness of others**. It removes the competitive, comparative tension from the relational field so that another's well-being directly increases one's own.

Phenomenology:

- A sparkling, effervescent joy that ignites whenever anyone is happy, successful, or free from harm.
- The nervous system feels like it is "fizzing" with celebration when others flourish.
- Zero envy; instead, a sense of "your gain is literally my gain."

Domain location:

- The **relational / contact field**: the energetic interface between "me" and "you," where threat, comparison, and resonance arise.

Distortions it purifies:

- Envy, rivalry, and subtle resentment.
- Inferiority/superiority narratives and status anxiety.
- Social threat-perception and hypervigilance.

Practice pointer:

> "Their happiness splashes into me—I am celebrating at least as much as they are."

6.4 Upekkhā — Stabilizing the Boundary Domain

Upekkhā is the purification and stabilization of the **boundary / perimeter field**. It is "immeasurable equanimity" (DN 13.78) and "purity of mindfulness due to equanimity" (MN 10.38), not indifference or coldness.

Functional definition
Upekkhā is **vast, cool, unshakeable clarity** that holds all phenomena without preference or resistance. It is the structural evenness of the mind's boundary: nothing can push or pull it off center.

Phenomenology:

- A sense of wide, open sky around all experience—everything moves within this, nothing disturbs it.
- Joy and sorrow, gain and loss, praise and blame appear as equal ripples in a much larger stillness.
- Action becomes precise and appropriate because nothing is being defended.

Domain location:

- The **boundary / perimeter field**: the outer "edge" or containment of awareness.

Distortions it purifies:

- Over-responsiveness and emotional flooding.
- Boundary collapse and enmeshment.
- Agitation by external stimuli (news, conflict, praise, blame).

Practice pointer:

> "Spacious, clear, untouchable—everything arises and passes in this open sky, and nothing needs to be pushed or pulled."

6.5 The Fully Developed Brahmavihāras as Summit State

When any single Brahmavihāra is developed to an immeasurable extent, the Canon speaks of "liberation of mind" (cetovimutti) based on that dwelling. When **all four** are developed together, stably and without limit, the texts treat this as the **highest accessible meditative state for a human being while still in a body**.

The early sources and classical commentaries converge on three points:

1. The simultaneous, boundless Brahmavihāras constitute the **foremost liberation of mind short of full arahantship**:
    - "The liberation of mind through the four Brahmavihāras is the foremost liberation" (e.g., AN 4.125 / MN 83, paraphrased).
    - One who dwells pervading all directions with these abidings has "a mind like a Brahmā" (AN 6.13).
2. When supported by the **fourth jhāna** and made truly boundless, this is technically equivalent in quality to the mind of an arahant in fruition (phala-samāpatti):
    - The Visuddhimagga (IX.108–112) states that when all four are fully developed and without limit, the mind is liberated "just as in the fruit-attainment of arahantship," differing only in permanence and depth.
3. This configuration—fourth jhāna plus boundless Brahmavihāras—is sometimes described as **"breaking the boundary"** (sīmā-samugghāṭa):
    - From the stillness and one-pointedness of the fourth jhāna, the Brahmavihāras are radiated in all directions without limit (ceto-vimutti brahmavihāra-vasena).

    - The sense of inside vs. outside collapses; space is experienced as continuous with the "heart."
    - Perception of the body may become very faint or vanish altogether.

In practical terms, advanced practitioners in multiple lineages report a recognisable phenomenology when all four Brahmavihāras run simultaneously at this level:

- The chest is infinitely radiant and warm (mettā).
- That radiance actively finds and dissolves any appearance of pain (karuṇā).
- Every instance of joy, anywhere, is amplified into effervescent celebration in one's own system (muditā).
- All of this is contained within a vast, cool, unshakeable clarity (upekkhā).

The composite experience is often described as:

- **Joy that has no opposite.**
- **Love that has no specific object.**
- **Clarity that is completely full and completely empty at the same time.**

This configuration is explicitly said in the Theravāda tradition to be **indistinguishable in quality** from the arahant's fruition-mind while it lasts, differing only in duration and in the fact that underlying tendencies (anusaya) have not yet been permanently uprooted. In later Mahāyāna and Vajrayāna language, the same state is described as the **union of emptiness and compassion** or as the spontaneous radiance of bodhicitta—different conceptual frames for the same fourfold, boundless heart-field.

Within the four-domain architecture proposed in this paper, the fully developed Brahmavihāras therefore represent:

- the **completion of purification** in all four domains;
- the **maximal coherence** the system can achieve short of irreversible structural transformation (arahantship);

- a **repeatable, cross-traditional summit state** accessible to serious practitioners, monastic or lay, given sufficient training in ethics, jhāna, and domain literacy.

Everything below this is preparation. Everything above this (full arahantship, nirodha-samāpatti) is best understood as what happens when this architecture not only appears and stabilizes, but ceases to be vulnerable to regression under any condition.

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7. The Interlocking Architecture of Jhāna and Brahmavihāra

This section outlines the functional relationship between the four jhānas and the four brahmavihāras, demonstrating how purification (brahmavihāra) and stabilization (jhāna) operate on distinct but interdependent layers of the conscious system. When correctly understood, these eight components form a coherent architecture in which each brahmavihāra occupies a specific experiential domain, purifies a distinct class of distortion, and prepares the terrain for the corresponding jhānic stabilization.

7.1 Correct Definitions and Phenomenological Locations of the Brahmavihāras

Each brahmavihāra is traditionally described as an immeasurable state (appamāṇa-vihāra) that suffuses consciousness “above, below, across, everywhere” (DN 13.76–78; Khp 9.6–9.8). These descriptions indicate that the brahmavihāras function as field-wide purifications, not discrete affective states.

The correct functional definitions are as follows:

7.2 Mettā — Somatic Non-Hostility (Purifies the Body Field)

Canonical definition:
“A mind of goodwill… expansive, exalted, immeasurable, without hostility or ill will.” (DN 13.76; AN 4.125)

Phenomenology:

- Felt as warmth, openness, and absence of aversion in the body field.
- Removes contractions and defensive somatic patterns.
- Produces whole-body friendliness and safety.

Domain location:
The somatic field (temperature, tension, breath, pressure).

Distortions it purifies:

- Aversion, threat-response, protective tightening.

7.3 Karuṇā — Emotional Responsiveness (Purifies the Emotional Field)

Canonical definition:
"Abundant, exalted, immeasurable compassion for all beings." (DN 13.76)

Phenomenology:

- A subtle, soft emotional current radiating from the chest.
- Dissolves turbulence, resistance, and emotional defensiveness.

Domain location:
The subtle affective field (tones, moods, interior atmospheres).

Distortions it purifies:

- Sorrow, emotional contraction, resentment, withdrawal.

7.4 Muditā — Relational Clarity (Purifies the Relational/Contact Field)

Canonical definition:
"Gladness… abundant, exalted, immeasurable." (DN 13.77) — associated with the removal of envy and hostility (AN 5.161).

Phenomenology:

- A clean, resonant openness toward other beings.
- Removes comparison and threat-projection in the interpersonal field.

Domain location:
The relational/contact interface between self and other.

Distortions it purifies:

- Envy, rivalry, inferiority, superiority, social contraction.

7.5 Upekkhā — Boundary Equanimity (Stabilizes the Boundary Field)

Canonical definition:
"Equanimity… abundant, exalted, immeasurable." (DN 13.78) — also described as producing "purity of mindfulness due to equanimity." (MN 10.38)

Phenomenology:

- A stable perimeter or "sphere" of awareness.
- Not indifference; rather, non-reactive containment.

Domain location:
The boundary/perimeter field of consciousness.

Distortions it purifies:

- Over-responsiveness, permeability, agitation by external stimuli.

7.6 How the Brahmavihāras Prepare the Ground for Jhanic Stabilization

Purification precedes stabilization. A domain cannot enter jhānic configuration while polluted by reactive patterns.

Here is the functional alignment:

7.6.1 Mettā → First & Second Jhāna: Somatic Safety Enables Unification

Mettā removes somatic aversion and contraction. The Buddha describes first jhāna as involving:

- "secluded from sensuality and unskillful qualities" (MN 39)
- "rapture and pleasure born of seclusion"
- "unification of mind" (MN 44)

Somatic goodwill is the condition that allows:

- full-body unification

- suppression of aversive micro-contractions
- whole-system coherence

Without mettā, somatic tension fragments attention and blocks entry into first jhāna.

7.6.2 Karuṇā → Second & Third Jhāna: Emotional Turbulence Yields to Stillness

Second jhāna requires:

- “internal confidence”
- “stillness of directed thought” (MN 44)
- stable, quiet emotional tone

Compassion (karuṇā):

- softens turbulence
- dissolves emotional aversion
- creates a breathable emotional field

Third jhāna requires a fading of rapture and the presence of:

- “quiet happiness”
- “contentment” (MN 39)

Karuṇā is the purification process that enables this emotional neutrality.

7.6.3 Muditā → Third Jhāna: Relational Reactivity Must Be Removed

Third jhāna is characterized by:

- “equanimous, mindful, happy” (MN 39)
- absence of social agitation or comparison
- stable interpersonal neutrality

The relational domain cannot stabilize if polluted by:

- envy
- social threat
- competitive comparison
- inferiority/superiority formation

Muditā purifies these distortions. Only then can relational experience become still enough to support the third jhāna.

7.6.4 Upekkhā → Fourth Jhāna: Boundary Stabilization Enables Equanimity

Fourth jhāna is defined by:

- “purity of mindfulness due to equanimity” (MN 10.38)
- “neither-pleasure-nor-pain”
- total non-reactivity

Upekkhā purifies the boundary field:

- firming the perimeter
- preventing external agitation
- creating evenness of mind

Only upekkhā produces the conditions for unshakeable stability characteristic of the fourth jhāna.

7.7 How the Jhānas Stabilize the Terrain Purified by the Brahmavihāras

The relationship is reciprocal:

- Brahmavihāras clear distortions so jhāna can arise.
- Jhānas stabilize the same domains the brahmavihāras purified.

This can be stated as:

> Purification removes reactivity.
> Stabilization locks the purified domain into coherence.

- **First Jhāna** — stabilizes the somatic field: unifies body and breath; removes instability caused by aversion.
- **Second Jhāna** — stabilizes the emotional field: removes turbulence; creates affective stillness.
- **Third Jhāna** — stabilizes the relational field: removes interpersonal reactivity; fades joy into equanimous happiness.
- **Fourth Jhāna** — stabilizes the boundary field: perfects non-reactivity; creates permeation-proof equanimity.

7.8 How the Brahmavihāra–Jhāna System Fits Together Like a Puzzle

Each brahmavihāra is a “wall” of the dwelling place (vihāra). Each jhāna is the “locking mechanism” that solidifies that wall.

- Mettā purifies the somatic interior → first/second jhāna unify and seal it.
- Karuṇā purifies emotional space → second/third jhāna quiet and stabilize it.
- Muditā purifies relational space → third jhāna neutralizes social reactivity.
- Upekkhā purifies the boundary → fourth jhāna perfects equanimity.

When all four domains are purified and stabilized, the Buddha describes the resulting state as:

- “the Brahmā dwelling” (brahmavihāra)
- “the Brahmā state” (brahmabhūta) (DN 13.80)
- “unshakeable liberation of mind” (MN 140)
- “immeasurable” (appamāṇa)
- “non-agitated” (AN 10.208)

The mind becomes a complete, coherent, self-stabilizing field, immune to external disturbance. This is the functional architecture of awakening described in the early Canon.

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8. Insight Practice as System Diagnostics

With the domains purified and stabilized, insight reveals:

- **Impermanence (anicca)** — flux of domain contents.
- **Unsatisfactoriness (dukkha)** — instability of conditioned patterns.
- **Non-self (anattā)** — absence of ownership in any domain.

Insight then produces:

- **disenchantment (nibbidā)**
- **dispassion (virāga)**
- **release (vimutti)**

The Canon repeatedly asserts that this sequence ends in “the destruction of the taints” (āsavakkhaya) (DN 13.80).

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9. Final Integration: The Completed Architecture of Consciousness

When the four domains of consciousness have been purified through the brahmavihāras and stabilized through the four jhānas, and when insight has revealed their uniformly conditioned nature, the entire conscious system undergoes a structural shift. This shift is described in the Pāli Canon not as mystical enlightenment, but as the emergence of a fully coherent, unshakeable mind-field.

This section describes the nature of that final integrated state.

9.1 Canonical Descriptions of the Integrated Mind-State

Across the Nikāyas, the Buddha consistently uses functional, architectural metaphors to describe the final outcome. The liberated mind is:

- **“Brahmabhūta” — become Brahmā-like** (DN 13.80; AN 10.208) — not a deity-state, but a mind that is immeasurable, expansive, and complete.

- **“Appamāṇa” — immeasurable / boundless** (DN 13.76–78) — all domains have been expanded without obstruction.

- **“Aneñja” — unshakeable** (MN 140.7) — boundary field is fully stabilized; no external contact produces reactivity.

- **“Aneñjasamādhi” — imperturbable concentration** (MN 106) — stabilization is not temporary; it is now structural.

- **“Aparāpariyāyena nibbāna” — the unbinding that admits no further dependence** (SN 43).

These terms describe the functional properties of a completed architecture, not metaphysical union.

9.2 Structural Characteristics of the Integrated Mind

The integrated mind has four features:

1. **Somatic Quietude and Friendliness (Mettā Field Completed)**
   The body-field no longer generates defensive patterns. There is no contraction, no aversion, no bodily disturbance. The Canon calls this “non-hostility” (averaṃ) and “without ill will” (asapattaṃ)” (SN 46.54; Khp 9.8).

2. **Emotional Clarity and Non-Turbulence (Karuṇā Field Completed)**
   Emotions arise without distortion or secondary reactivity. The affective field is open, soft, and breathable. This corresponds to “purity of citta” (MN 10.38) and the “fading of the taints” (MN 2).

3. **Relational Non-Reactivity (Muditā Field Completed)**
   Comparison, envy, insecurity, and threat-responses vanish. Interpersonal contact does not disturb the system. The Canon describes this as “without rivalry” (AN 5.161) and “endowed with goodwill toward the world” (DN 13.77).

4. **Boundary-Field Equanimity (Upekkhā Field Completed)**
   The perimeter of the mind becomes stable, sealed, and evenly distributed. This is the meaning of the 4th jhāna description: “purity of mindfulness due to equanimity” (MN 10.38) and the final liberation description: “unshakeable freedom of mind” (akuppā

cetovimutti) (MN 140).

9.3 How the Four Domains Interlock in the Final State

The Buddha repeatedly described the brahmavihāras as abodes (vihāra) — dwellings. A dwelling is stable only when all four walls are upright and sealed.

- If somatic safety collapses → aversion rises.
- If emotional clarity collapses → turbulence rises.
- If relational clarity collapses → envy/hostility rises.
- If boundary stability collapses → reactivity rises.

Integration is the moment all four domains support each other.

The structure becomes:

- self-coherent,
- self-stabilizing,
- self-correcting.

This is why the Canon describes the final state as:

> “This, monks, is a mind without seams.” (SN 12.61)

A seam is a place where stress leaks in. The integrated mind has none.

9.4 Why This State Is Unshakeable

The mind becomes “unshakeable” (aneñja) not because it is in a special state, but because:

- the somatic domain no longer tightens,
- the emotional domain no longer resists,
- the relational domain no longer compares,
- the boundary domain no longer wavers.

When all four domains have no reactive seeds, external conditions have no leverage.

This is the Buddha's meaning when he says:

> "The wise person is not shaken by contact." (SN 35.97)

9.5 The Force-Field Analogy

The four purified, stabilized domains create a force-field-like structure around consciousness:

- Mettā → warmth radiating in the interior body.
- Karuṇā → softening and absorbing turbulence.
- Muditā → clear, resonant relational contact.
- Upekkhā → stable perimeter blocking reactivity.

When integrated, they form a complete energetic geometry that:

- neutralizes external impacts,
- prevents internal turbulence,
- maintains clarity,
- creates systemic resilience.

This structure makes the mind function as a closed, coherent system, allowing insight to cut the final linkages.

9.6 Why People Reached Liberation Quickly in the Buddha's Time

The Canon frequently mentions rapid awakenings (e.g., MN 146, AN 5.30, SN 22.59). This becomes intelligible under the four-domain architecture:

- The Buddha gave direct instructions targeting the domains.
- Brahmavihāra training was widely understood and correctly taught.
- Jhāna was considered standard literacy.

- Ethical restraint was culturally ubiquitous.
- Conceptual distortions (e.g., “mettā = loving-kindness”) did not exist.
- Practitioners had direct exposure to someone with the completed architecture.

Modern practitioners lack:

- correct definitions,
- domain-level understanding,
- proper sequencing,
- integrated systems thinking,
- cultural support.

The system is intact, but its organizing logic was lost.

9.7 Completion vs “Enlightenment”

The English word “enlightenment” is historically imported from Christian mysticism (“illumination by God”). It misrepresents the Buddha’s description.

The Pāli terms emphasize:

- unbinding (nibbāna),
- completion (pariyosāna),
- perfection of the path (ariyamagga-sampatti),
- unshakeability (aneñja),
- non-agitation (anupaddava),
- peace (santi).

These describe a structural transformation, not an illumination. It is not a light appearing; it is a system finishing its construction.

9.8 Summary of the Final Integrated State

The liberated mind:

- has no reactive seeds,
- maintains perfect equanimity,
- responds without distortion,
- remains unified under all conditions,
- sees all phenomena as conditioned,
- experiences freedom without remainder.

This is the functional definition of nibbāna as presented in the Canon.

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10. Comparison to Modern Contemplative Models

Framework	Overlap	Divergence
Wilber (Integral)	Multi-dimensional development	Lacks domain phenomenology; relies on metaphysical nondualism
Ingram (MCTB)	Clear phenomenology; insight mechanics	No domain architecture; brahmavihāras peripheral
Brown (Mahamudra/Dzogchen)	Subtle-field descriptions; stabilization	Ground-of-being metaphysics differs sharply
Culadasa (TMI)	Attentional unification	Does not integrate brahmavihāras or multi-domain purification

The four-domain architecture more closely reflects early canonical structure than any modern system, restoring the functional relationships that contemporary models only partially capture.

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11. Conclusion

This paper has proposed a structural reconstruction of the Buddha's path as a four-domain architecture of consciousness, grounded in the early Pāli Canon. By identifying and correcting key historical distortions—emotionalization of the brahmavihāras, mystification of the jhānas, Western metaphysical overlays, and the reduction of meditation to attention training—it has clarified why the original system's coherence has been difficult to perceive in modern contexts.

Re-situating the training within the Noble Eightfold Path, ānāpānasati, and satipaṭṭhāna, the model interprets meditative development as a process of domain purification (through the brahmavihāras), domain stabilization (through the jhānas), and structural diagnosis and release (through insight). The final integrated state, described in the Canon as brahmabhūta, appamāṇa, and akuppā cetovimutti, emerges not as a mystical event but as the completed, unshakeable configuration of a fully coherent conscious system.

This four-domain architecture offers a unifying framework for reconciling diverse contemplative traditions and modern contemplative science. It suggests new research directions in phenomenology, cognitive science, and clinical practice, particularly around domain-specific interventions for somatic, emotional, relational, and boundary-level reactivity. Most importantly, it restores the Buddha's path as a precise, practicable, and internally consistent system for the completion of consciousness.

Appendix A: Conceptual Models for the Brahmavihāras (Recognition Framework) for the Brahmavihāras (Recognition Framework)

This appendix provides simple, intuitive, somatically accurate conceptual models for each Brahmavihāra. These models are not for *visualization* or *emotional imitation*—they serve as **recognition templates**, helping practitioners understand what each state *actually is* so it can be identified and stabilized.

Before one can cultivate a Brahmavihāra, one must know **what its field-state feels like**. These models give the nervous system a clear blueprint.

A.1 Why Conceptual Models Matter

A practitioner cannot access or stabilize a state they cannot recognize.

Conceptual models:

- provide a correct intuitive “shape” of the state,
- prevent emotional misinterpretation,
- allow the body to align with the right somatic configuration,
- accelerate entry into both Brahmavihāra and jhānic states.

These are not metaphors—they are **somatic patterns** that mirror the structure of each Brahmavihāra.

A.2 Mettā — “The Friendliness Field”

Core Model: The feeling when you suddenly see someone you deeply like.

A friend shows up unexpectedly, or a loved one turns the corner at the airport.

Somatic signature:

- Chest brightens and expands.
- Breath opens.
- Body becomes unarmored.
- There is an immediate, effortless “yes.”

Why this works: This moment contains **pure, non-hostile somatic openness** without obligation, sentimentality, or moral framing.

Mettā is this state without the object—radiating everywhere.

A.3 Karuṇā — “The Soft Chest”

Core Model: The warm, hopeful feeling before you reconnect with someone you care about.

You haven’t heard from them in a while. You hope they’ve been well. You want things to be good for them.

Somatic signature:

- Heart softens and moves slightly forward.
- Emotional field becomes warm and breathable.
- Subtle oscillation or gentle wave in the chest.

Why this works: Real karuṇā is **emotional availability**—not sorrow, pity, or heaviness. This model bypasses all distortions.

Karuṇā is this warm, responsive openness, scaled to infinity.

A.4 Muditā — “The Sparkling Resonance”

Core Model: Laughing because someone else is laughing.

Or hearing someone you care about share good news—and feeling your body light up.

Somatic signature:

- Buoyant, upward-moving joy.
- A “fizzing” or sparkling sensation in the chest or face.
- A sense of celebration without comparison.

Why this works: Muditā is not cheerfulness or cheerleading.
It is **the body resonating with another’s goodness**—a relational field becoming bright and open.

Muditā is this resonance purified and made boundless.

A.5 Upekkhā — “The Blanket State”

Core Model: Being a child wrapped in a blanket.

Warm, held, safe, contained—but completely free inside that containment.

This is one of the most precise and universal matches for the boundary-field configuration of equanimity.

Somatic signature:

- Soft containment with no pressure.
- Even temperature and tone across the whole body.
- Vastness without effort.
- A stable perimeter around experience.

Why this works: Upekkhā is not detachment or distance.
It is **perfectly stable containment**—the mind held the way a blanket holds a child: warm, even, unshakeable.

Upekkhā is this containment scaled to the size of the world.

A.6 Using These Models in Practice

These conceptual models should be used **before** meditation sessions, or anytime a practitioner cannot locate the correct state.

Protocol for using a model:

1. Recall the model for 1–2 seconds only.
2. Let the body shift into the correct configuration.
3. Drop the memory or image.
4. Allow the state to radiate and expand.
5. Stabilize in the domain corresponding to that Brahmavihāra.

Appendix B: Mapping Words to Inner Experience (Conditioned Forms of the Brahmavihāras)

The single hardest part of Brahmavihāra practice is **mapping the words to the correct inner experience**. English glosses like “loving-kindness,” “compassion,” or “sympathetic joy” distort the practices into emotions or moral attitudes. But the Buddha himself reclaimed the path by **remembering an effortless childhood state** (MN 36)—a natural, non-conceptual, felt-sense configuration of consciousness.

This appendix shows how to locate the *conditioned forms* of the Brahmavihāras—states every person has already experienced—and use them as experiential doorways into the **unconditioned, boundless versions** described in the Canon.

B.1 Why Mapping Inner Experience Is Difficult

Modern practitioners struggle because:

- The traditional English terms mislabel the actual experiences.
- Most people try to *feel emotions* rather than *inhabit field-states*.
- The Brahmavihāras are not emotions; they are **modes of consciousness**.
- Each mode corresponds to extremely familiar human experiences, but we rarely examine them directly.

The solution is to return to **pre-verbal, bodily-felt states**—the same strategy the Buddha used.

B.2 The Surprise-Party Model

Imagine you open a door and find in the room all the friends and family you haven't seen in a long time—people you miss, feel warmly toward, and wish you could reconnect with. They have come to surprise you.

1. Mettā — The Immediate Flood of Friendliness

As soon as you see them, your chest brightens, softens, and expands.

This immediate, involuntary, whole-body friendliness is conditioned mettā.

2. Karuṇā — The Warm Hope That They Have Been Well

Before you even speak to them, you imagine reconnecting—how good it will feel to talk to them, to hear how they've been, to know that they are okay.

This anticipatory emotional warmth is conditioned karuṇā.

3. Muditā — Joy in Hearing Their Joy

When you finally embrace or talk to them, and they start sharing the good things in their life, you feel uplifted.

Their joy *makes you more joyful*. You are happy because they are happy.

This resonant uplift is conditioned muditā.

Together, these three conditioned states provide the **somatic templates** for the unconditioned Brahmavihāras.

B.3 Conditioned → Unconditioned (Sāmisa → Appamāṇa)

The surprise-party feelings are:

- specific,
- personal,
- dependent on particular people,
- momentarily triggered.

These are the *conditioned* (sāmisa) versions.

The Brahmavihāras are the same states, but:

- objectless,
- universal,
- limitless,
- self-sustaining.

Practice involves:

1. Finding the *somatic configuration* of the conditioned state.
2. Dropping the personal story.
3. Expanding the felt-sense outward until it becomes objectless.
4. Holding it steadily until the field becomes boundless (appamāṇa).

This is precisely what the Canon means by:

> "Above, below, across, everywhere… without hostility, without ill will." (DN 13.76–78)

B.4 Childhood Archetypes for Each Brahmavihāra

The Buddha remembered a childhood state of natural ease to rediscover the path (MN 36). Every person has early-life analogues for the four Brahmavihāras.

These are the most universal:

Mettā — Somatic Friendliness

Childhood: the moment after a parent comforts you; body relaxes fully.
Adult: seeing someone you love unexpectedly and feeling an immediate warm "yes."

Karuṇā — Soft Emotional Availability

Childhood: wanting a friend or pet to stop hurting.
Adult: hoping someone you care about is okay—even before you ask.

Muditā — Pure, Resonant Joy

Childhood: laughing because your friend is laughing uncontrollably.
Adult: your happiness amplifying because someone else is thriving.

Upekkhā — Equanimous Holding / Safety

Childhood: lying in grass watching clouds—nothing to push or pull.
Adult: awe, stillness, vastness; moments when everything is allowed to be.

These memories are *doorways*, not objects of meditation.

B.5 Using Conditioned States as Practice Doorways

Step-by-step protocol:

1. Recall the memory only for 1–3 seconds.
2. Identify the felt-sense of the state in the body.
3. Reproduce the physical configuration (breath, chest shape, muscle tone).
4. Drop the memory-image immediately.
5. Let the felt-sense expand outward in all directions.
6. Remove the specific people from the field; keep the state.
7. Allow the field-state to become spacious, then boundless.

Key principle:
You are training the **nervous system configuration**, not the story.

B.6 Short Guided Sequence: “The Surprise-Party Method”

The Doorway Sequence (Conditioned Forms → Brahmavihāra Fields)

1. **Open the door and see people you love.**
   *The instant, bright, effortless friendliness in your chest → **mettā** (somatic non-hostility).*

2. **Imagine reconnecting, hoping they’ve been well.**
   *The warm, soft, forward-moving emotional openness → **karuṇā** (emotional availability).*

3. **Imagine hearing their good news.**
   *The uplift, sparkle, celebratory resonance → **muditā** (relational clarity and non-comparison).*

4. **Imagine the safe, enclosed feeling of being wrapped in a blanket as a child.**
   *The stable, even, unshakeable containment → **upekkhā** (boundary equanimity).*

5. **Let all four states mix and expand outward in all directions.**
   Allow the internal imagery to dissolve; keep only the somatic field-configuration.

6. **Rest in the boundless field.**
   The scene disappears; the pattern remains.

The four Brahmavihāras are now running.

B.7 Common Pitfalls & Corrections

Pitfall: Using bittersweet memories that trigger grief.
Fix: Choose neutral or warm memories with no longing.

Pitfall: Staying too long in visualization.
Fix: Use the image only as a key—drop it immediately.

Pitfall: Trying to manufacture emotions.
Fix: Focus on bodily configuration, not feelings.

Pitfall: Confusing upekkhā with detachment.
Fix: Check that the field is vast, cool, and gentle—not numb.

B.8 How This Appendix Supports the Main Architecture

This appendix exists because most practitioners fail at the **very first step**: mapping the concept of a Brahmavihāra to a real, embodied, somatic-experiential state.

By grounding practice in conditioned forms:

- The mapping becomes intuitive.
- The domains become easy to identify.
- Brahmavihāra states become reproducible.
- Jhānic stabilization becomes dramatically easier.
- Integration becomes possible for non-monastics.

The Buddha rediscovered the path through **somatic remembrance**.
This appendix operationalizes the same method.

Appendix C: Stepwise Brahmavihāra Cultivation (Practice Protocol)

This appendix provides a concise, practice-oriented sequence for cultivating the four Brahmavihāras in alignment with the four-domain model. It is designed for direct use on the cushion, without reliance on emotional imitation or conceptual visualization. Each step cultivates the field-state appropriate to its domain using felt-sense cues.

C.1 Prerequisites (5–10 minutes)

Before beginning cultivation:

- Settle into natural breathing (ānāpānasati).
- Sense the four domains: body, emotional tone, relational field, boundary field.
- Establish basic somatic safety: loosen the jaw, belly, eyes, hands.

C.2 Mettā Practice (Somatic Domain)

Aim: Unarmoring the body; establishing somatic non-hostility.

Instructions:

1. Bring attention to the chest and belly.
2. Breathe gently into any tightness without forcing it to change.
3. When a small area softens, amplify that softness outward.
4. Let warmth spread through the torso, arms, and face.
5. Radiate this friendliness through the whole body-mind field.

Cue:

> "Nothing in this body is against anything in the world."

Sign of correctness:

- Whole-body ease, warmth, non-aversion.
- Breath feels unconstrained and pleasant.

C.3 Karuṇā Practice (Emotional Domain)

Aim: Dissolving emotional turbulence through luminous responsiveness.

Instructions:

1. Rest awareness in the center of the chest.
2. Sense the emotional field as a texture or atmosphere.
3. Allow a warm, gentle wave to move outward with each exhale.
4. When meeting pain (your own or others'), let the heart brighten and soften.

Cue:

> "A radiant wave flows from my heart and dissolves suffering the moment it appears."

Sign of correctness:

- Emotional turbulence quiets.
- Soft, breathable atmosphere inside the chest and head.

C.4 Muditā Practice (Relational Domain)

Aim: Clearing social threat, envy, comparison; amplifying resonant joy.

Instructions:

1. Bring to mind any being experiencing goodness, joy, ease, or success.
2. Let the body respond *physically*—allow a fizzing or brightening in the chest or face.
3. Feel their happiness mixing with your own, increasing it.
4. Notice the absence of comparison.

Cue:

> "Their joy splashes into me; I celebrate with them effortlessly."

Sign of correctness:

- Effervescent joy with no tension.
- The relational field feels open, non-defensive, and resonant.

C.5 Upekkhā Practice (Boundary Domain)

Aim: Establishing a stable, even, unshakeable perimeter to the mind.

Instructions:

1. Expand awareness outward until you sense the “edge” of your field.
2. Allow this perimeter to become even, cool, and stable.
3. Let all experiences—pleasant or unpleasant—arise inside this vastness.
4. Do not push anything away or pull anything toward you.

Cue:

> "Everything moves in this sky; nothing disturbs its openness."

Sign of correctness:

- Spacious clarity.
- Reactivity drops to near-zero.
- Boundary feels firm but gentle.

C.6 Combined Brahmavihāra Practice (Advanced)

After stabilizing each Brahmavihāra individually, combine them in ascending order:

1. **Mettā** fills the whole body with warm, friendly non-aversion.
2. **Karuṇā** radiates outward, finding and dissolving any trace of suffering.

3. **Muditā** celebrates every joyful ripple in the field.
4. **Upekkhā** holds all movements in vast, cool equanimity.

Practice until the four operate simultaneously without strain.

Composite cue:

> "Warm, radiant, joyful, spacious—everything is included, nothing is resisted."

Signs of correctness:

- Joy without opposite.
- Love without object.
- A unified, coherent field-state.
- Boundary dissolves into all directions.

C.7 Integration with Jhāna

For practitioners with jhāna experience:

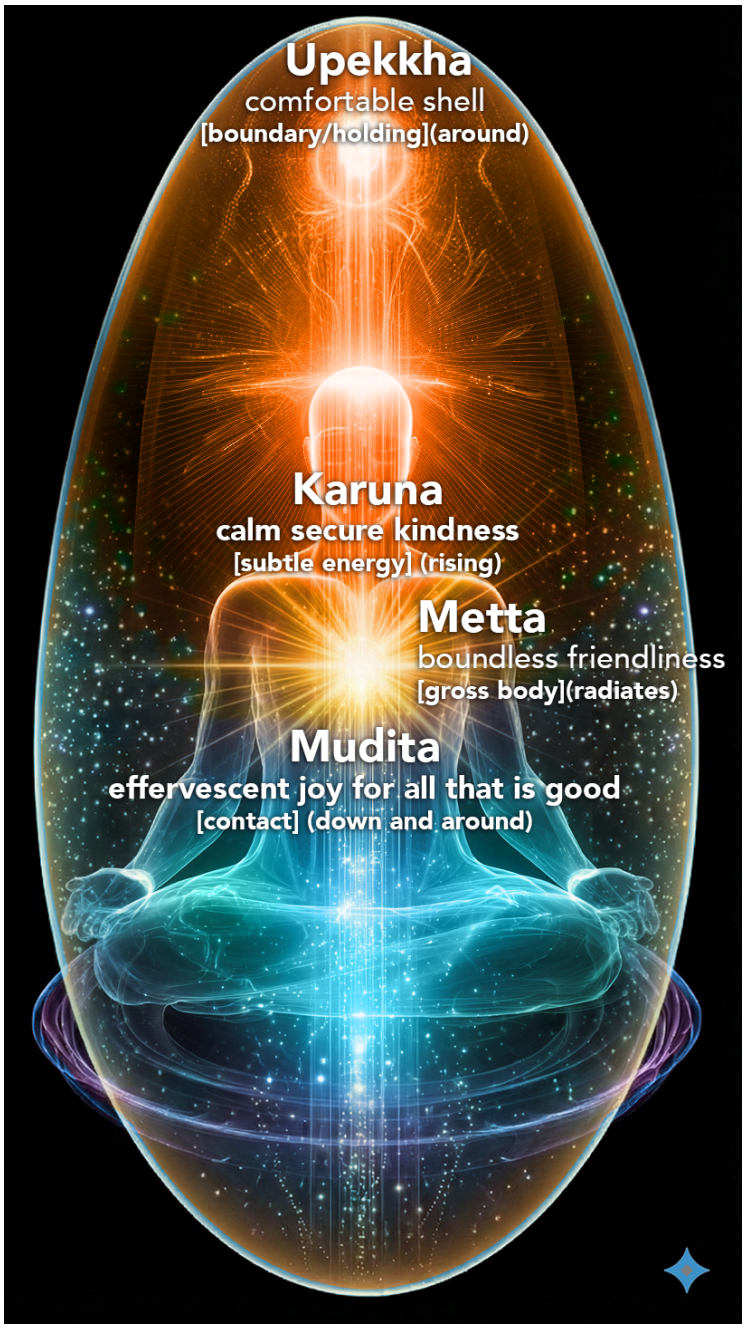
1. Enter fourth jhāna (pure equanimity, unified attention).
2. Gently “release” the mind outward in all directions.
3. Allow the Brahmavihāras to radiate from this stillness.

This is the configuration called **ceto-vimutti brahmavihāra-vasena**—the liberation of mind via the divine abodes.

C.8 Recommended Session Structure

- 5 minutes ānāpānasati calibration

- 5–10 minutes mettā
- 5–10 minutes karuṇā
- 5–10 minutes muditā
- 5–10 minutes upekkhā
- 10–20 minutes integrated cultivation (ie mettā+upekkhā) / jhāna-supported radiation

This sequence maps precisely onto the four-domain architecture and supports both purification and stabilization.

Appendix D: Direct Access Cues for the Four Divine Abidings